



UMA BHARATI

She won Madhya Pradesh for BJP. Later, the firebrand mass leader was sidelined by the central leadership and had to quit.



VINAY KATIYAR

Popular Hindutva face of BJP, the OBC leader helped refurbish the UP unit in the 1990s. Now languishing at the party headquarters.



SIPRA DAS

YASWANT NEGI

RAVI S. SAHANI

ing it like their personal

GOPINATH MUNDE, GENERAL SECRETARY, BJP

ership for her exit. Other grassroots leaders like Babulal Marandi in Jharkhand, Dilip Singh Judeo in Chhattisgarh, B.S. Koshiyari in Uttarakhand are complaining of being sidelined by the central leadership. Like Bharati, Marandi quit the party after he was overlooked in favour of Arjun Munda, a Venkiah Naidu loyalist, for chief ministership in 2005. Bharati too

was made to give up chief ministership and has since been replaced by lightweight (though OBC) leaders who enjoy patronage of the centre. Another popular chief minister Vasundhara Raje has been saddled with her bete noire as party chief. It is arguable whether Om Mathur, an RSS pracharak, has been sent to help her or to keep her in check. Even in the recent Rajya Sabha elections, the party nominated as many as five Brahmins even though only one had retired. Few of these are vote gatherers.

The party has not bothered to cultivate leadership amongst many dom-

inant castes in north India. In Punjab, it depends on the Akalis. In Haryana, Kishan Sangwan, the only Jat leader it has, is an export from the Indian National Lok Dal. In Uttar Pradesh not only is it losing its upper caste base but is making little attempt to reach out to the others.

The urban, upper class face of the party is the one that dominates the central leadership in Delhi. Careful to avoid such a charge, the party has gone in for cosmetic surgery and accommodated the right amount of OBC, ST and SC leaders at the party office. But they are kept out of the decision-making process. Very few of these grassroots leaders have a say either at the party office or at Advani's residence. Let alone BJP, even the Sangh hierarchy is dominated by Maharashtrian brahmins. Most of the second rung leadership sits in the Rajya Sabha. Nowhere is the lack of a strong mass-based leadership more visible than in the Lok Sabha. Advani has no choice but to lead from the front. Hardly surprising that he has now asked all the GenNext leaders to contest the next Lok Sabha elections. Each is now scouring the countryside for a "safe" seat.

At last, as the party gets ready for E-2009, it is realising the importance of leaders with mass base, even if they come from the wrong caste. So a Yeddyurappa has become a potential chief minister, a Bharati may stage a dramatic homecoming, a Sushil Modi can drop an upper caste from the Cabinet and continue to be the deputy chief minister, and Munde can't be taken for granted. Even in a party like BJP, every underdog has his day.

with Farzand Ahmed, Shyamal Yadav and Stephen David

